

Women in Boardrooms

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

ent does not work for those who are only intelligent but for those with empathy, and that helps retain and hire talent,” says Girotra.

WAY AHEAD

Shriram Subramanian, Founder and Managing Director of InGovern Research Services, a corporate governance advisory firm, says India is one of the few countries where women’s representation on boards is mandated by the regulator (the Securities and Exchange Board of India). “The turning point was in 2017 when the Kotak Committee report recommended at least one independent woman director,” he says. This was after it observed that several promoter-driven organisations had appointed relatives after the new Companies Act and the SEBI LODR (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) mandate in 2014.

While India has a clear ‘one woman’ mandate, several countries opt for a percentage. That is viewed as a key reason for the sharper rise in the women representation abroad. “We must move away from having one or two women directors and have a threshold; 30% is a good

number,” says Hazarika. Still, inherent biases cannot be wished away, and she refers to “microaggression” from other board members and how making oneself heard can become extremely difficult at times.

“If we have to move away from networking, there must be an increase in the number of tests/exams to increase the talent available,” she says. From a regulation point of view, there must be stricter guidelines for non-compliance, she adds.

Subramanian disagrees that there is a dearth of women directors. He says there are enough women in senior management who can take up directorships. “Gender diversity is much needed, and boards should appreciate the benefits,” he says. But the process is taking time. Subramanian looks at diversity a little differently and insists it must go beyond just having women on the board. “Gender diversity for the sake of it will never work. The objective should be to have a diversity of views and opinions.”

Swetha Joseph, Director, DEI Practice, Talent Solutions, Aon Consulting India, says inclusion is an act of broadening representation, such as on key board committees or at workplaces. A simple way to start is by examining what biases or stereotypes are preventing the expansion, she says. “For instance, instead of using the traditional qualifications or criteria to recruit a board member, such as previous experience in the C-Suite, companies can break down the specific skills that are important, which are usually honed by being in the C-Suite, but need not be limited only to those who have had the experience in those specific roles.” This will immediately expand the pool of potential candidates and encourage diversity of industry, areas of expertise, and field of work, she says, adding this could even add generational diversity into the mix.

The larger effort lies in understanding how a woman director makes a tangible difference to the board. Hazarika says data proves that diversity leads to more innovation and improved performance. “With diversity, discussions get more productive. Women are known to raise issues related to ESG or bring in a different approach to strategy, leading to a more rounded view,” she says. That’s not the only thing. Hazarika emphasises women laying stress on better working conditions. On this, Purohit has a simple view. “A woman’s viewpoint is obviously different from that of a male and allows us to look at a problem differently.” Girotra is optimistic and thinks regulation will ensure there are two women on a board.

So, while progress has been made, there is still a long way to go. **BT**

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SUKANYA HAZARIKA
DIRECTOR, KHAITAN & CO



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APURVA PUROHIT
CO-FOUNDER, AAZOL